

"DEATH IN WAR HAS BEEN LOWER THAN ON ROADS"

NITIN GADKARI, the *Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways*, is deeply concerned about the mounting accidents on India's highways and has launched a range of measures to reduce the risks. But in an interview to *Group Editorial Director* Raj Chengappa *and Associate Editor* Avishek G. Dastidar, he candidly admits that this is one area where he has failed to meet the targets he set. Edited excerpts from the interview:

Q. How serious is the problem of highway accidents in India?

The problem is very, very serious. Every year, there are 4.6 lakh accidents and 1.68 lakh deaths, and we are losing an estimated three per cent of India's GDP because of these. Some 33 per cent of these accidents occur on our national highways. Of these, 60 per cent of the deaths are of people aged between 18 and 34. Even when fighting extremist organisations, the death toll is much lower. Even in the wars we have fought, the death toll has been much lower.

Q. What accounts for the high fatality rates?

There is one problem in our country that is not present in other parts of the world—there is neither respect for the law nor fear of the law. That is a big problem. We have taken a lot of preventive measures, including mandatory seat belts, electronic braking systems, and these are being implemented according to the latest technology and other requirements. For cars, we introduced the Bharat New Car Assessment Programme (NCAP), which assigns star ratings based on their safety performance. Because of the star rating we have introduced for vehicles, six airbags have now become mandatory. We are taking similar measures for buses and trucks too.

Q. What about observance of lane discipline and licence issues?

Maintaining discipline is very important. Elsewhere in the world, heavy vehicles stick to one lane but, in India, no one follows that. This is one of the reasons we face so many accidents. There are even people who drive on the wrong side of the highway. On the Delhi–Meerut highway last year, a school bus driving on the wrong side to save time collided with an SUV and six people of the family in the SUV were killed. There is also a problem with driving licences in India. It is so easy to get one here, whereas in the USA, if you want a driving licence, you have to pass a written test.

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